



△ **Courtyard** of the Lions

Spanish Alhambra

The Alhambra in Granada, Spain, is recognizable from afar for its distinctive brickwork made from red clay and gravel: its name means “red castle”. The interior is a marvel of stonework and decoration in sandstone, stucco, and wood. Sandstone has long been an important building material. Its durability as both a building and a sculptural material is unsurpassed among sedimentary rocks. Stucco is a fine plaster used to coat walls and moulded into decoration. Used together in the Alhambra, they suffuse the interior with a warm glow and a wealth of textural detail.

In its heyday, the Alhambra was a citadel and palace, but it has since been used as a barracks, prison, and Roma settlement, with farm animals roaming the ruined halls. The Romantics rediscovered it in the 19th century, inspired by its former glories. One famous visitor was Washington Irving, author of *Rip Van Winkle*. Irving invented a history for the citadel’s Hall of the Two Sisters, involving a pair of Muslim

princesses who fell in love with their Christian captives. One eloped with her suitor, while the other remained behind, a forlorn spinster. The reality is more prosaic – the “sisters” are two large marble



Engraving showing the Alhambra, 1890

flagstones on the floor. This hall was part of the residential quarters, where the *Sultana* (ruler) lived with her children. Its outstanding feature is the muqarnas dome in the centre. Muqarnas is an intricate form of tiered vaulting, made of painted stucco. Based on a geometric design, it has thousands of overlapping, stalactite-like “cells” – possibly a visual reference to the cave in which Muhammed received the revelation of the Koran.



Ceiling of the Hall of the Two Sisters: this worm’s-eye view of the interior of its muqarnas dome shows its cell-like patterning in stucco

**It absolutely
appears to me
like a dream**

Washington **Irving**
Author

Key dates

889 CE–1984

